

statements based on a set of rules by reusing the terms in the user's statements. It gave the impression that it was an intelligent human being. Though when it was first launched it was scripted to respond to users as a psychiatrist, ELIZA could be modified to respond in different milieu by changing the set of rules.

September: Ralph Baer's First Game

At Sanders Associates, Ralph Baer invented a video game in which two dots chase each other around a screen. The video game industry is believed to have had its origins in his work. While



An early game console with a light gun

there were games that could be run on mainframes, Baer was interested in creating games that could be played at home with the TV as display. Initially though there was a lot of interest, the first commercially-available console only came out in 1972, and allowed the user to switch between games like ping-pong, volley ball, and shooting games.

Long-distance Data Transfer

The modem was first created in 1960 and was used to convert (digital) data from the computer into analogue sounds (and vice versa) that could be sent (and received) over ordinary telephone lines. But because these modems were very susceptible to noise in phone lines, long distance data transfers were not practical, and modems were restricted for data transfer across short distances, mostly within the building. John van Geen of the Stanford Research Institute changed all that. His modified modem reliably detected bits of data despite background noise, making long-distance data transfers feasible for the first time.